



Talk SHOP

Shopping for a digital device is no fun and games. So take your shopping seriously and pay attention to what other proud owners have to say

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It used to be about *phoren maal* once upon a time—the imported car, the gold watch and electronic goodies. But all that is easily available in India now. So how do you get to be one up on Mr Gupta?

You, of course, flaunt your tech-savviness by casually fishing out a Palm device to check your appointments and read e-books or talk knowledgeably about the music scene and Napster as you listen to music on that cool MP3 player. And at parties, you capture the moment with a digital camera and generously send the images to all your friends by e-mail.

But before you go out to satisfy your ego drive, ready with a bundle of cash to buy the funkier digital accessories around, take heed! Shopping for such hi-tech gadgets calls for more than mere window-shopping. With the combination of looks and performance that these gadgets pack, there is quite a bit of work that you should put in before getting your hands on one!

The window dressing

First, you need to figure out the different choices available to you. There are plenty of Web sites that give you information about buying trends all over the world as well as detailed reviews of products, which can help you make an effective buying decision. Several magazines, TV shows and newspapers also have sections that display

the latest products, though it probably makes sense to pick a magazine or Web site that can give you detailed information on the various brands and models available. “Getting to know about the latest digital cameras is not difficult if you watch Discovery, CNN, BBC, etc. They show you all the latest gadgets,” says Sandeep Sheth, an avid technology enthusiast.

After you have a list of the various products that exist, and have set your mind on one, the next step is to figure out which features are really important to you. “I saw the Rio Volt portable MP3 player on Cnet.com in a review of the top five MP3 players and was bowled over by its cool features. It can play songs in the MP3, CDA and



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